

HCL Beanstalk 4455

Black beauty with a punch

The Beanstalk 4455 is the latest offering from HCL Infosystems, targeted at the home segment. The cabinet is matte black with a silver front, and the monitor is half silver, half black.

and a complete suite of multi-lingual software.

The PC also comes with an external TV-tuner card and a handy remote. The 80 GB hard disk ensures that you don't run out of space for

your favourite movies. However, the GeForce2 MX 2400 graphics card does not do justice to the configuration. It is the only component that seems out of place, and keeps this Beanstalk from qualifying as a high-end PC.

The PC also has good Linux compatibility—we installed RedHat 9.0, and found that everything worked smoothly.

At close to Rs 70,000 it is a little steep, but the excellent build, original Intel feature-rich motherboard, flat-screen monitor, Altec Lansing speakers and bundled software make this computer worthy of any home.

SPECIFICATIONS

Intel Pentium 4 2.66 GHz, 256 MB DDR SDRAM (333 MHz), 80 GB 7,200 rpm hard drive, 16X DVD-ROM, 40X12X40X CD-RW, 56K internal modem, 1 year onsite maintenance

HCL Beanstalk 4455 B+	
Performance	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Build Quality	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Value for money	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Features	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
OVERALL	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶

The PC comes with an original Intel D845PEBT2 motherboard—the best board in the 845 series, with features such as 5.1 channel sound, serial ATA controller, optical SPDIF output, etc. It has a pre-installed internal modem, Ethernet, both a DVD-ROM and a CD-RW drive for CD-to-CD copying. This last move seems bad, as a combination drive would have reduced the price considerably.

To complement the onboard 5.1 sound system, the PC comes bundled with 5.1 channel Altec Lansing speakers—the wooden sub-woofer gives out heart stopping bass, and the satellites produce good quality sound. The Beanstalk 4455 also comes with a small USB rumble effect gaming wheel that lets you feel the bumps on the road when playing those F1 simulation games. The bundled software includes MS Encarta (Indian edition)

Price: Rs. 69,990

Contact: HCL Infosystems Ltd

Phone: 0120-2520977

Fax: 0120-2533877

E-mail: raman@hclinsys.com

Web site: www.hclinfosystems.com

Gainward GeForce FX 5800 Ultra

Force 10 from nVidia

When we received the big FX Power Pack from Gainward, we wondered how large the card was to warrant the humongous packaging. On opening the box, the monstrous graphic card with huge heat sinks on its front and back was a sight to see. The device is really thick and will occupy the neighbouring PCI slot with the elevated heat sink fins that ventilate hot air from above the core. It has a Molex power connector (like the one that goes to the hard disk) to quench its thirst for power.

The fan speed varies according to the load placed on the card. It's quiet, and runs at low speeds when working with non graphic-intensive applications, but whines like a jet turbine the moment a user enters the world of 3D.

This card has some features that no other card has. The Ultra runs at a clock speed of 500 MHz, with its memory clocked at 1 GHz. It supports the latest industry standards, such as DirectX9 and OpenGL 1.4, vertex and Pixel shader 2.0, which means the user will get to see more realistic water, grass and walls in games. There are some issues over the pixel per clock—nVidia claims it's 8 pixels per clock, but in some cases such as Z rendering + colour, it reduces to 4 pixels. All said and done, the specifications look pretty good on paper, making it decently future proof.

The card is indeed a performance warehouse, giving a high score of 286.7 fps in

Quake III Arena at a 1280 x 1024 x 32 resolution. The scene in *Serious Sam SE* was the same. Although the demo started with a few jerks, there was no stopping Sam in his killing spree. Everything was rendered instantaneously and without any kind of artifacting or jaggedness. In VulpineGL Mark, the 3D world was rendered with ease—the whole benchmark finished in half the time that the SiS Xabre600 took—with a score of 59.9 fps at 1280 x 1024 x 32.

This card still isn't the fastest card overall, because the 9800 Pro from ATi is already out, and has an improved and faster core. The 9700 Pro still

manages to take the lead in many benchmarks and is available at a lower price. Only games such as *DOOM 3*, when released, will tell us which card is better for the games of the future. On the price front, this card is unaffordable to the majority, but the privileged few who can afford it will get a 5.1 channel sound card, a FireWire card, a *Duke Nukem: Manhattan Project* CD and InterVideo WinCinema DVD playback software.

SPECIFICATIONS

125 million transistors, 0.13 micron fabrication process, DirectX 9 and OpenGL 1.4 compliant, 500 MHz core clock, 1 GHz memory clock, 128 MB DDR II memory

Gainward GeForce FX 5800 Ultra A-	
Performance	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Build quality	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Value for money	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Features	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
OVERALL	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶

Price: Rs 37,975

Contact: Mediatech India

Phone: 022-5639 6696

Fax: 022-2201 4083

E-mail: sales@mediatechindia.com

Web site: www.gainward.com